

SPIRIT-FILLED!

Celebrating Pentecost is different this year. While some are disappointed at not being able to celebrate in person at church, this is an opportunity to experience the work of the Holy Spirit in new ways. Pentecost in the Jewish tradition was known as the Festival of Weeks. The Festival of Weeks occurred fifty days after the Passover celebration. When the disciples met for the Festival of Weeks and the Holy Spirit entered like a rush of wind giving them the ability to speak different languages, the church was born—and Pentecost took on new meaning.

New Life

The Gospel of John reports that before Jesus died, he assured the disciples that they would never be alone: “The Companion, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, will teach you everything and will remind you of everything I told you” (John 14:26). Even though Jesus appeared to his disciples after his resurrection and spent time with them, it was not the same as it had been.

We too have experienced distance from our church family. Meeting online is not the same as being together in the flesh! Yet, the Holy Spirit breathed new life and purpose into the room where the disciples gathered, and it quickly spread far beyond their dreams. On this Pentecost, we too can experience the Holy Spirit breathing new life and purpose into us as we figure out how to navigate what lies ahead.

New Purpose

Even though we have the Holy Spirit as our Helper, we may feel like we do not know where or how to start. Fortunately, the Holy Spirit has given us creative gifts. We are called to listen, follow, and faithfully pursue new ways to reach new people during this time. Having our physical buildings closed forces us to work outside of those buildings, to learn new ways of worshiping and sharing God with the world, and to receive and use the gifts of the Spirit in ways we never before attempted nor imagined!

We are called to listen, follow, and faithfully pursue new ways to reach new people during this time.



PENTECOST SUNDAY

TIP FOR THIS ISSUE

This week encourage teens to share with their family or parents the focal Scriptures in this issue's Teacher Bible Prep (also included as the first three daily Bible readings on Youth Page 6). Suggest teens talk with their parents about new ways of being the church while physical church buildings are closed and people cannot meet together in person. Encourage teens to dream about what the Holy Spirit may be asking us to do with our gifts during this challenging time. Invite teens to share their feedback and ideas next week!

SPREADING THE SPIRIT

Question of the Day: How do you describe the Holy Spirit?

Purpose: To help teens celebrate the church and share the Holy Spirit.

Cultural Connection: Celebrating Pentecost

Topic: Holy Spirit

A FIERCE WIND

Acts 2:1-12, 38-41

Suddenly a sound from heaven like the howling of a fierce wind filled the entire house where they were sitting.

—Acts 2:2

Commentary:

Working outside the laws of nature is commonplace for God, Jesus, and the Holy Spirit. But it was never commonplace for humans to experience a burning bush, walking on water, or a rush of wind that ushered in the ability to speak in tongues. After Jesus' resurrection, the disciples continued to meet and share Jesus' teachings. But the powerful arrival of the Holy Spirit gave them abilities to reach people in new ways. The infusion of the Holy Spirit, which brought miraculous gifts for the believers to share with all people, was the birth of the church established on the teachings of Jesus and the history of the Jewish people of Israel.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ Close your eyes and imagine the sound and feel of a fierce wind where you are right now. What do you imagine hearing and feeling?
- ▶ How did the ability to speak different languages help spread the teachings of Jesus?
- ▶ Aside from preaching to and baptizing others, what else did the believers do?
- ▶ In what ways could God or the Holy Spirit be working during this time of pandemic to continue to spread the message of salvation?

FILLED WITH THE SPIRIT

Acts 9:1-20

Ananias went to the house. He placed his hands on Saul and said, "Brother Saul, the Lord sent me—Jesus, who appeared

"... the howling of a fierce wind filled the entire house . . ."

[Acts 2:2]

to you on the way as you were coming here. He sent me so that you could see again and be filled with the Holy Spirit."

—Acts 9:17

Commentary:

Saul was on his way to Damascus to punish and imprison more of Jesus' followers. Along the way he met the risen Jesus, was blinded, and then led to Damascus where he spent three days fasting and praying in darkness. When Ananias arrived to visit Saul and lay hands on his eyes, the Holy Spirit intervened to restore his sight and fill him with the Holy Spirit. Saul's conversion story is famous, but we often overlook those three days of darkness, confusion, prayer, isolation, and other emotions Saul experienced. Just as Jacob wrestled with God, Saul wrestled with God before Ananias arrived and then the Holy Spirit restored Saul's sight.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ Why do you think Saul spent those three days in darkness?
- ▶ Who was skeptical of Saul's conversion?
- ▶ Have you seen people who appeared to be filled with the Holy Spirit?
- ▶ Have you ever felt filled with the Holy Spirit?

GIFT OF THE SPIRIT IN YOU

1 Corinthians 12:1-11

A demonstration of the Spirit is given to each person for the common good. —1 Corinthians 12:7

Commentary:

After his conversion and traveling throughout Turkey and Greece to establish faith communities, Paul (formerly Saul)

TEACHER BIBLE PREP

wrote letters to the churches to help settle disputes, answer questions, and encourage believers. Then, as today, there were many questions about the Holy Spirit, the gifts of the Spirit, and whether some gifts were more important than others. Paul answered by talking about the variety of gifts given and the need for all gifts in a community. In the last half of chapter 12, he relates the gifts to the parts of the body, reminding readers that just as all parts of the body are necessary, all gifts of the Spirit are necessary.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ Who decides who will receive which gifts?
- ▶ When and how are gifts of the Spirit given?
- ▶ Have you observed gifts of the Spirit in others? How would you describe those gifts?
- ▶ Do you feel like you have gifts of the Spirit? If so, what gifts are being used for the common good through you?
- ▶ How does sharing your gifts help spread the Spirit?

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DEVOTION: BORN OF THE SPIRIT

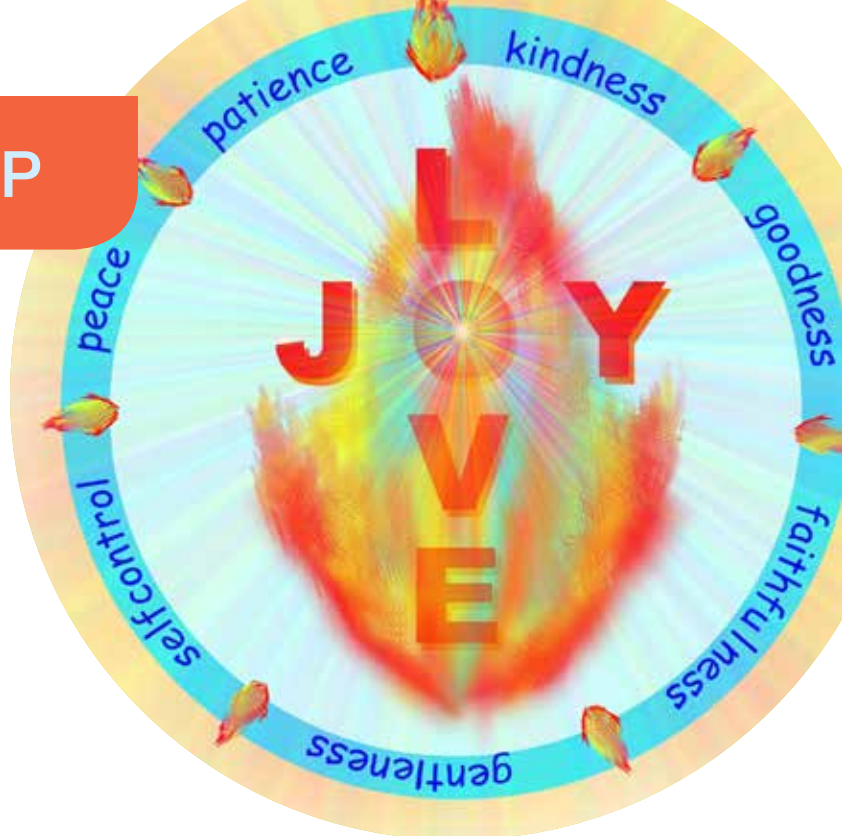
Read John 3:1-8 and spend some time reflecting on the Holy Spirit. If you are unfamiliar with The United Methodist Church's beliefs about the Holy Spirit you can find information at <https://www.umc.org/en/content/by-water-and-the-spirit-a-united-methodist-understanding-of-baptism>.

Even within a denomination there may be wide differences in belief and experience regarding the Holy Spirit. Remember, it is not our job to decide what the Holy Spirit is or how it operates. Because "God's Spirit blows wherever it wishes" (verse 8a), our task simply is to follow the Spirit.

Prepare to meditate for a few minutes by closing your eyes, taking deep breaths, and clearing your mind of distractions. As you breathe, focus on the Holy Spirit and ask yourself:

- What does the Holy Spirit want of you in the next ten minutes? the next hour? this day?

Now, ask the Holy Spirit to reveal a gift in you that can be used to help others. Listen for what the Holy Spirit might be telling you. Breathe deeply and close your meditation time by expressing gratitude for the Holy Spirit. Practice this time of meditation each day for the next week and take note of any changes.



"God's Spirit blows wherever it wishes. You hear its sound, but you don't know where it comes from or where it is going. It's the same with everyone who is born of the Spirit." —John 3:8

NEXT WEEK: Of all the emotions and attitudes we've encountered during the past few months, gratitude may have been one of the most elusive to find. Next week in LINC we'll talk about ways to seek gratitude even during difficult and challenging times.

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LINC
LIVING IN CHRIST

WE'VE GOT SPIRIT! YES, WE DO!

Getting Ready: Ahead of time, email Youth Page 6 to teens and ask them to join the call with a Bible, a pen or pencil, a small (personal) fan, if available, and some sort of camera cover for their device. Also invite teens to download a candle app on a smartphone, while using another device (if available) to join your virtual meeting.

OPEN

Happy Birthday! (10 minutes)

Say: "Today is a special day on the church calendar. Does anyone know what event the church celebrates today?" If someone names Pentecost, then use the information on Page 1 to introduce today's topic. If no one can name the day, ask if teens know anything about the birthday of the church. Now ask teens to open a candle app and light their candle on their phone or tablet while you use the information on Page 1 to introduce today's topic. Then ask:

- ▶ How many of you have celebrated birthdays during this pandemic?
- ▶ What are some things we can do to celebrate this birthday of the church?

Lead group in singing "Happy Birthday!" Remind teens that we use candles not only to celebrate birthdays but also the flame can represent the Holy Spirit. Ask everyone to keep their candle app available and, when they want to answer or ask a question, to hold up their candle.

EXPLORE

Talk Topic 1: Say What? (15 minutes)

Middle School Option

Invite teens to turn in their Bibles to Acts 2:1-12, 38-41. If you or some teens are using a laptop, open Acts 2 on

www.biblegateway.com and then open Google Translate. Copy and paste the text of Acts 2:1-4 into Google Translate. Select a language in which to translate the passage, then select "listen" and turn up the volume so everyone can hear the translation. Now, invite a teen to choose and play the Scripture in another language. Listen to the passage in four to six different languages, if time allows.

Now invite teens to turn on their personal fans while you ask the questions in Teacher Bible Prep to lead a discussion about the presence of the Holy Spirit.

High School Option

Begin by asking the Question of the Day and allow time for a few responses and discussion. Then ask, "How many of you can read or speak one or more different languages?" If no one speaks a second language, ask teens to open their Bibles to Acts 2:1-4 and use Google Translate on their phone or another device to translate the passage to another language. If any teens can read Spanish, French, or other languages, ask them to read aloud the translation. Or, use the speaker function and listen to the Scripture. If teens have a small personal fan handy, invite them to turn it on while you lead a discussion around the Holy Spirit using the commentary and questions in Teacher Bible Prep.

BONUS SMALL GROUP DISCUSSION

Invite teens to go to (or share your laptop screen) www.biblegateway.com and choose the Common English Bible translation for a search of "Holy Spirit." As everyone scrolls through the search results, ask teens:

- ▶ What do these Scriptures tell you about the Holy Spirit?
- ▶ How do the number of references to the Holy Spirit in the Old and New Testaments compare?
- ▶ Where can you find a list of some of the gifts of the Holy Spirit? (Read aloud the gifts.)
- ▶ What are some ways you believe the Holy Spirit may be active today?

Talk Topic 2: What Do You See? (20 minutes)

Middle School Option

Ask teens to use their camera covers during this activity. Make sure everyone's video is on to start. Next, call out one person's name and ask him or her to cover his or her camera or turn off the video for a moment and make one slight change to his or her appearance.



WE'VE GOT SPIRIT! YES, WE DO!



When the video is restored, allow everyone to guess what is changed about the person. The first person to guess correctly goes next. Continue play for a few minutes, and then ask everyone to cover their cameras or turn off video functions while they change one thing about their appearance. One by one, allow teens to guess what has changed about each person's appearance. Continue as time allows.

Now, ask, "What is it like to not be able to see everyone?" After a few responses, ask teens to read Acts 9:1-20 silently, then ask and talk about the following:

- ▶ How do you think Saul felt when he could see again?
- ▶ Do you think Saul saw the world differently?
- ▶ How might our time of sheltering in place be similar to what Saul experienced?

Use the commentary and questions in Teacher Bible Prep to continue your discussion.

High School Option

Consider using the previous middle school activity. Or, ask teens to open their Bibles to Acts 9:1-20 and take turns reading aloud the passage. Use the commentary and questions in Teacher Bible Prep to lead a discussion about Saul's conversion to Paul and being filled with the Holy Spirit. Next, invite teens to reflect on their experience during the shelter-in-place precautions and how it might be similar in any way to what Saul experienced. Enhance your discussion by asking the following:

- ▶ Have you been questioning life a lot more lately, or wondering why all this is happening?
- ▶ Are you viewing life differently because of what the world is experiencing?

Talk Topic 3: Gift Opening (15 minutes)

Middle School Option

Invite teens to read aloud 1 Corinthians 12:1-11, one or two verses each. Use the commentary and questions in Teacher Bible Prep to

lead a discussion around the gifts of the Spirit. Next, ask teens to complete the "Gift Opening" activity on Youth Page 6. If teens have trouble identifying their individual gifts, share what you see in them.

After several minutes, invite teens to share what they wrote in their gift boxes. Also, if possible, show the image on this page. If they need suggestions of ways to help others during this time, brainstorm ideas as a large group. Then ask and talk about the following:

- ▶ How can all of us be more open to the Holy Spirit and the gifts of the Spirit?
- ▶ How can we share gifts of the Spirit virtually?

Invite teens to light their candles in the app as you close in prayer and thank God for the Holy Spirit, the church, and this time to gather. Ask God to help everyone spread their gifts and the power of the Holy Spirit in all they do this week.

High School Option

Consider using the devotional, "Born of the Spirit," on Page 3. (You may want to ask everyone to turn off or cover their camera during the meditation time.)

Invite teens to read 1 Corinthians 12:1-11 silently, then use the commentary and questions in Teacher Bible Prep to lead a discussion about the gifts of the Spirit. Ask the same questions provided in the middle school option:

- ▶ How can all of us be more open to the Holy Spirit and the gifts of the Spirit?
- ▶ How can we share gifts of the Spirit virtually?

Invite teens to light their candles in the app while you close in prayer and thank God for the Holy Spirit, the church, and this time to gather. Ask God to help everyone this week to embrace their gifts and recognize the power of the Holy Spirit in and through their lives.

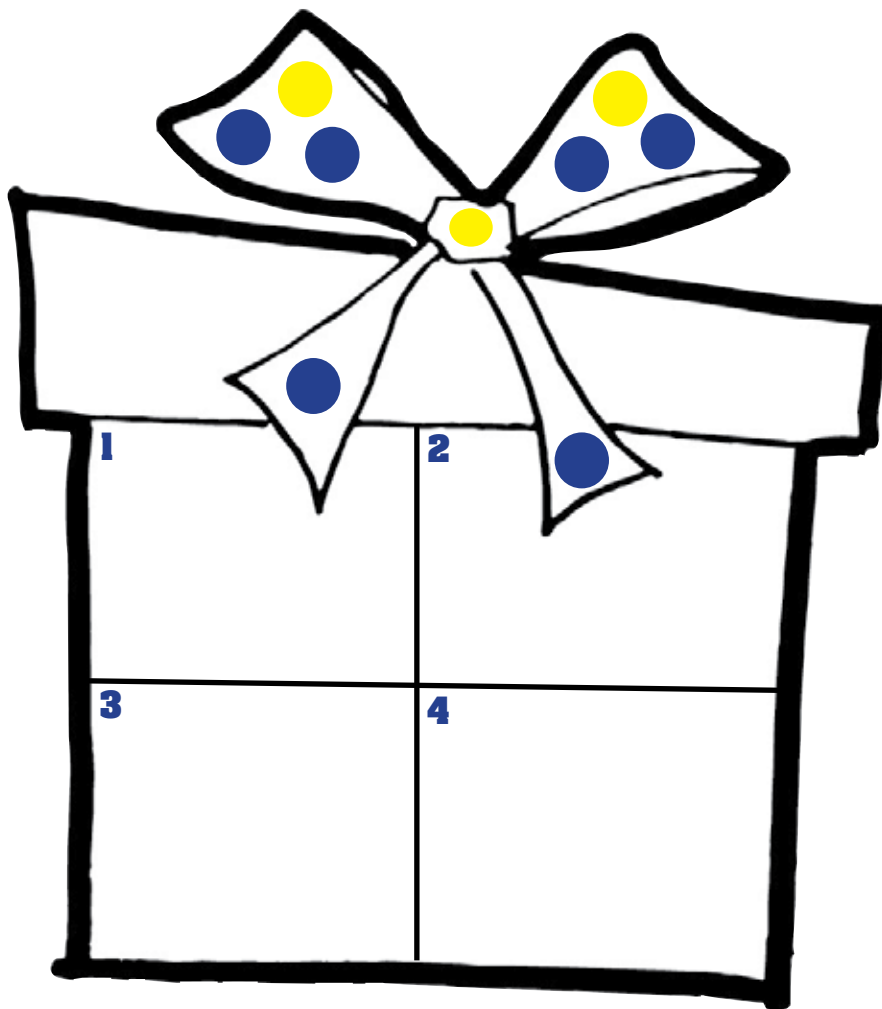
TAKE AWAY

Even though we cannot meet as groups of believers in our churches during this time, let's remember that the Holy Spirit remains active and we can celebrate or spread the Spirit in powerful ways. In these challenging days, let's follow the Holy Spirit's nudging and keep spreading God's love and salvation!

WORKING IT OUT

GIFT OPENING

The gifts of the Spirit are meant to be used to help others. Use the gift box instructions provided to explore your gifts and ways you can use them.



INSTRUCTIONS

1. In the top left section, list things you do well.
2. In the top right section, list things you like doing to help others.
3. In the bottom left section, list the gift(s) given to you by the Holy Spirit (Review the things you wrote in the top sections and ask your classmates for their ideas.)
4. In the bottom right section, list people you could help (especially during this time) using the skills you are already good at, or with your gifts.

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In the Bible: Readings for the Week

MONDAY: Read Acts 2:1-12, 38-41.

Do you sense the movement of the Spirit during this time?

TUESDAY: Read Acts 9:1-20.

Being filled with the Spirit does not have to be so dramatic. How do you sense the Spirit working in you?

WEDNESDAY: Read 1 Corinthians 12:1-11.

How might your gifts work with others' gifts?

THURSDAY: Read 2 Samuel 23:1-2.

What evidence do we have that the Lord's Spirit spoke through David?

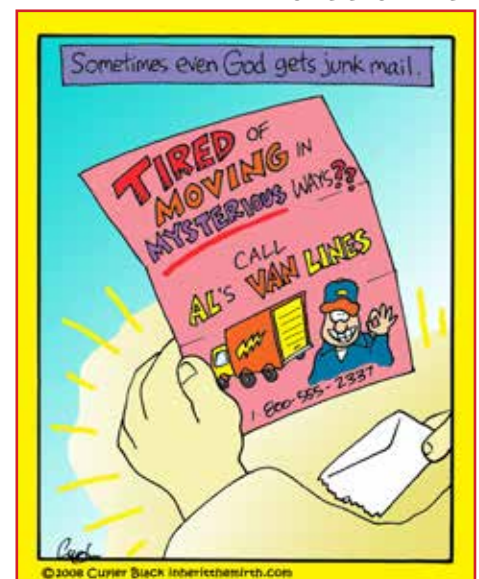
FRIDAY: Read John 16:12-16.

You can trust the Holy Spirit to lead you.

SATURDAY: Read 2 Corinthians 3:1-6.

Look for evidence of the Holy Spirit bringing life.

Inherit the Mirth



WHAT'S TRENDING?

When have you felt God moving in your life in a new way? Tweet or post your response with the hashtag #comeholyspirit on Twitter to @YMPartners or on facebook.com/youthministrypartners